STATUS REPORT

Malawi — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-09-01 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Malawi's two headline digital strategies were both still drafts in February 2026, when the Ministry of ICT's Department of E-Government and UNDP opened validation of a Draft National Digital Transformation Strategy and a Draft National AI Strategy at a Lilongwe workshop alongside a public feedback portal. The AI strategy had entered regional consultative workshops only in September 2025, run with UNDP and the Public Private Partnership Commission. No national cloud strategy has been adopted either: one is still being developed under the World Bank's Digital Malawi Acceleration Project (2025). There is no government open source policy and no recorded adoption programme in the public sector (2025).

What exists is the machinery rather than the documents: a government institution responsible for coordinating digital transformation is established and a current national digital transformation strategy is recorded as in force (2025). Delivery is spread across the sector bodies. MACRA holds spectrum and licensing, and cut radio-frequency licence fees by 20% across all bands in June 2025, presenting the cut as a digital inclusion measure aligned with the Malawi 2063 agenda. The National Registration Bureau's 2025–2030 Strategic Plan, launched in September 2025, aims for every birth, marriage and death to be registered by 2030, resting on six pillars from universal civil registration to interoperability and civic trust. The Reserve Bank launched a National Payments System Vision and Strategy 2026–2030 in April 2026, covering affordability, cybersecurity, resilience to power and connectivity failures, and regional integration.

Direction from the top runs ahead of the instruments. The February 2026 State of the Nation Address directed all ministries, departments and agencies to digitalise passports, ID cards, driver's licences and procurement "forthwith", with a digital identity wallet in testing. In July 2026 the ICT minister told parliament the government was considering licensing additional mobile network operators to improve competition and affordability, work for which technical assistance had already prepared MACRA by mid-2025. In August the finance minister committed the government and the Reserve Bank to secure, reliable and accessible digital financial infrastructure as cheques are withdrawn, with no coverage target and no date attached to it.

Legislation and regulation

Parliament passed the Bills of Exchange (Amendment) Bill on 6 August 2026, phasing out the cheque, with three consequential Bills stripping cheques and bearer negotiable instruments out of the Financial Crimes, Payment Systems and Deposit Insurance Corporation Acts. Government had already stopped using cheques in practice before the Bills reached the House, so the legislation ratifies a change made administratively rather than effecting one.

Most of what moved in 2026 was enforcement of older instruments against the telecoms operators. MACRA found Airtel Malawi and TNM in breach of section 76 of the Communications Act 2016, which requires an approved tariff change to be published in two daily newspapers seven days before it takes effect, and ordered both to tighten their internal compliance procedures (July 2026). A year earlier the Competition and Fair Trading Commission had ordered TNM to open its exclusive Super League e-ticketing platform on Mpamba to rival payment providers, finding the exclusivity breached the Payment Systems (Interoperability) Directive 2017 and the E-Money Regulations 2018 (July 2025).

The statute book underneath is a patchwork rather than a digital code. The legal basis for sharing government data rests on the Data Protection Act 2024, the Electronic Transactions and Cyber Security Act 2016, the National Registration Act, the Access to Information Act and the National Statistics Act with no single instrument governing exchange; the data protection statute leaves its own commencement to the Minister by notice in the Gazette. Consumer rights in electronic commerce, including cooling-off and cancellation, still come from the 2016 Act. New law arrives mostly as tax administration and ratification of external finance: the Value Added Tax (Electronic Invoicing System) Regulations were published on 9 January 2026, with enforcement later reset to 1 May 2026, and the Act ratifying the GESD 2.0 grant charges payments on the Consolidated Fund and exempts it from Malawian taxes and charges. Four of those statutes are now held in full and they are older than the digital agenda they serve: the Electronic Transactions and Cyber Security Act, chapter 74:02, in force since 1 June 2017, the Access to Information Act, Act 13 of 2017, commenced 30 September 2020, the National Statistics Act, chapter 27:01, commenced 19 July 2013, and an open data policy scoped to extractive-industry data and running to 2027. What remains unadopted is narrower than it looked: protection of critical information infrastructure, electronic signatures, an e-government and cloud instrument, artificial intelligence, open banking, and any open-data policy reaching beyond one sector. Three instruments arrived inside the window - the Tax Administration (Amendment) Act 2026, permitting disclosure of protected tax data to the Commissioner of National Statistics, the Competition and Fair Trading Regulations 2026, and a High Court ruling that the access to information law reaches private companies performing government contracts.

Data protection

The regime acquired rules to apply in October 2025, twenty months after the Act was gazetted: regulations on the engagement of data processors on 17 October and guidelines on personal data breach notifications and communications on 22 October. The authority itself was still being built by consultancy at the same date, the World Bank-financed acceleration project tendering for technical support to operationalise the Act, including the unit's organogram, enforcement framework and fees. Nothing on record shows either instrument enforced.

Malawi's first dedicated data protection statute was passed on 7 December 2023, assented on 31 January and gazetted on 2 February 2024. It is GDPR-shaped: data-subject rights, mandatory breach notification, an adequacy test for cross-border transfers and extraterritorial reach over processing of Malawian personal data from abroad. It imposes no localisation duty: sections 38 to 40 set conditions for transfer abroad — adequacy assessment, consent, binding corporate rules — and a duty to tell people when it leaves. Section 53 gives controllers of significant importance six months from commencement to comply, and all others twenty-four months.

The design decision that governs how the regime works is section 4, which makes the Malawi Communications Regulatory Authority the data protection authority rather than creating a standalone body. That is what was argued against at bill stage, when the analyst Moses Kaufa warned that housing the function inside the communications regulator would compromise its independence, urging a standalone Data Protection Commission (2022). MACRA holds powers to issue compliance orders, receive breach notifications and handle complaints, and has published a

Data Protection Handbook, and registers any body processing the data of more than 10,000 people. It now plans, with World Bank technical assistance, to spin the function out of the regulator into an independent institution (July 2026).

The public sees very little of it. Neither the regime nor the authority publishes reports on its operation (2025), though the law is recorded as in force and effective. The state used Data Privacy Week in January 2026 to declare compliance no longer optional. Visible consumer enforcement in 2026 came under communications law instead: Airtel Malawi and TNM agreed to credit affected customers with bundles worth the price difference by 31 July 2026, and a consumer petition asked the regulator to investigate data-billing and bundle depletion.

Regional collaboration

Malawi's cross-border digital reach is almost entirely a payments story. It is a member of the SADC Transactions Cleared on an Immediate Basis scheme, live since 2021; the April 2026 settlement statistics record nine Malawian banks and 1,210 settled transactions. The COMESA Digital Retail Payments Platform reached user trials between Malawi and Zambia in October 2025. Deeper regional integration is one of the commitments in the Reserve Bank's payments strategy for 2026–2030, launched in April 2026. Outside payments the estate stops at the border: the national identity card is built to the ICAO standard and used by the Immigration Department as a secondary document at border points (2020).

Standards

Government systems in Malawi exchange data with one another without any published rules for how: there is no government interoperability framework, no data-quality or service-availability standards for exchange, and no programme to bring legacy systems onto a common standard (2025). Standards are adopted one sector at a time instead. The Reserve Bank's payments strategy commits to migrating the national payments infrastructure to the ISO 20022 messaging standard (April 2026); the National Local Government Finance Committee and the Department of E-Government issued ICT standards for councils alongside the first dedicated Local Authorities ICT policy, validated on 4 May 2026; Malawi has begun adopting the Universal DPI Safeguards Framework covering inclusivity, trust and data compliance (2025); and the country's first integrated labour market information system was built around SDMX, the international statistical data-exchange standard, across six government and labour institutions in April 2026 - the only concrete international data standard in use that the record can name. The certifier itself was certified in the same period: the regional accreditation service renewed the Malawi Bureau of Standards's accreditation to certify quality management systems, effective 14 December 2025.

Where a standard does bite, it tends to come from a body acting on its own account. The Data Protection Act requires controllers "of significant importance" to register with the data protection authority, a duty whose threshold is set by regulation still to be made. The Copyright Society of Malawi, a statutory body, will not register works created entirely by artificial intelligence and will not pay royalties on them — a line drawn on AI authorship by a rights body, as at July 2026, before the state has adopted any national policy on the technology.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Malawians' own sense that they can speak freely has fallen further than almost anything else the governance indices measure about the country: perceived freedom of speech is the second most deteriorated of Malawi's 96 IIAG indicators, down 41.6 points over 2014–2023 to 49.1 out of 100.0 and 28th of 54 African states. The expert-coded measures sit far higher and move differently: Freedom of Expression and Belief scores 87.1 in 2023, 9th of 54 and up 4.7 points over the decade, while Media Freedom scores 65.0, 13th of 54, and has fallen 2.9 points. Digital Freedom, covering online censorship, shutdowns and rights online, is among Malawi's ten best indicators at 82.7, 8th of 54.

The room to organise has narrowed faster than the room to speak. Civil Society Space fell 25.9 points over 2014–2023 to 60.2, 21st of 54 — the third most deteriorated of the 96 indicators, and Deliberative and Participatory Governance, which measures consultation and participation in policy-making, stands at 64.2, 16th of 54, down 4.2 points over the same decade.

The standing routes in are new and narrow. As recently as 2025 every one of the twelve participation and feedback fields in the GovTech Maturity Index was recorded as absent for Malawi; since then the anti-corruption bureau has launched a mobile application letting citizens report corruption by text, audio or image with anonymity and case tracking (August 2025), government has opened a toll-free national short code for corruption, poor service delivery and abuse of office (February 2026), and Parliament and civil-society organisations met formally for the first time on 18 March 2026, launching a structured platform to replace fragmented engagement. None of the three publishes a count of what it receives or what it settles. Consultation happens as events instead: the two draft digital strategies were put to a validation workshop with a citizen feedback portal in February 2026, and pressure on the regulator over internet pricing arrived as an online petition in July 2026. An access to information law is in force, though the records it opens are published considerably better than they can be reached and used (2023). MACRA's own misinformation-tracking system drew criticism as mass surveillance and a threat to free expression (2025).

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

National Bank of Malawi and the ICT Association of Malawi signed a three-year memorandum of understanding in November 2025 covering mentorship and incubation for Malawian innovators. It is a cooperation framework, with no sum and no delivery obligation attached to it. Where digital arrangements in Malawi have actually bound a party to do something, they have been commercial and operational rather than signed as memoranda: Airtel Money and the state Agricultural Development and Marketing Corporation began paying farmers directly into mobile wallets in June 2026, a running service rather than a statement of intent.

New investments

About US$230 million of Malawi's digital finance — three World Bank operations — is approved but not yet recorded as disbursing, against about US$231 million across eight commitments that are active and about US$146 million across six that have closed. Eighteen commitments are on the record as at August 2026, with start years spanning 2012 to 2026 and a converted value of about US$607 million.

Parliament ratified the Governance to Enable Service Delivery Project 2.0 grant on 29 July 2026 — SDR 58.2 million of IDA, about US$80 million equivalent, signed on 19 June 2026 — inside a K229.5 billion package of two World Bank financing Bills. The Bank had already approved SDR 60.3 million, about US$80 million equivalent, for a Fiscal Governance Program-for-Results in April 2024, and appraised the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project at US$90 million: a US$70 million IDA grant plus US$20 million of unguaranteed commercial finance. Its predecessor closed in 2024.

The World Bank is by far the largest financier on the record to August 2026, with four commitments worth about US$302 million, roughly half the total; Chinese state lenders come second, with China Eximbank and China Construction Bank accounting for three commitments worth about US$204 million. Connectivity has taken the largest subsector share — six commitments worth about US$347 million, 57% of the total — ahead of government financial and administrative systems at about US$204 million. Ten of the eighteen commitments are grants, and borrowing is confined to connectivity infrastructure, most of it Chinese.

That borrowing sits in two projects: China Eximbank financed the National Fibre Backbone Project and its second phase, and China Construction Bank finances the Last Mile Connectivity for Rural Areas and National Data Centre project.

Elsewhere, Germany's BMZ has an active EUR 28.35 million grant to 2028 for public financial management systems; the EU has committed EUR 2 million and UNDP US$6 million to Inclusive Digital Transformation for Malawi over 2024-2028; KfW's EUR 12,996,804 e-learning grant closed in 2024 and the UK FCDO's GBP 4,737,206 Making Technology Work for Malawi in 2021. The only domestic commitment is National Bank of Malawi's MWK 75.5 million for the 2025 Innovation Jam in November 2025.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Wholesale bandwidth in Malawi fell from about US$460 per Mbit/s to under US$10 under the World Bank-financed Digital Foundations Project (June 2025), a collapse that has not reached the retail counter: a mobile broadband basket costs far more than the international affordability benchmark (2022).

Signal runs well ahead of use, and the gap has widened in the measuring. An industry association report published in August 2026 puts fourth-generation coverage at 87 per cent of the population against mobile-internet penetration of 12.5 per cent, with mobile-money adoption described as near universal — the association's own figures, not a regulator series. MACRA had put 4G population coverage at 75.1 per cent by the third quarter of 2024, while fewer than two in five people used the internet in 2022 and international bandwidth per user stood at 13 kbit/s. The Mo Ibrahim Foundation scored Malawi 9.0 out of 100 on internet and computer access in 2023, the second lowest of the 96 indicators it measures for the country.

TNM and Airtel have had the market to themselves since the 1990s, when the population was about 10 million against nearly 23 million now (July 2026). Malcel, licensed as the intended third operator, missed a late-2023 launch and has named no new date, and Nyasa Mobile, licensed in 2022, has never launched. The ministry is weighing further licences, but the constraint it concedes is not licensing: the ICT minister told Parliament in July 2026 that foreign-exchange shortages are limiting incumbents' imports of network equipment, and TNM names it as the binding limit on its own investment (November 2025).

Both operators have built anyway. TNM launched 5G in Lilongwe in July 2025 with Huawei as vendor and added voice over LTE on 5 March 2026; Airtel launched 5G in November 2025 and reported 111 sites across 10 districts by May 2026, after MK50.8 billion of capital spending in FY2025. Fixed-wireless provider CTN, outside the duopoly, switched on five more 4G base stations in August 2026, reaching 19 Lilongwe neighbourhoods. Outside the cities the state's own instrument is thin. MACRA is procuring some 90 to 100 towers under the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project and says the Universal Service Fund is under-resourced for the rural gap (March 2026); the project's predecessor connected about 640 government sites and more than 83,000 students through the research and education network, and most schools still have limited or no connection (April 2026).

Data Storage

Local hosting became a commercial proposition in May 2026, when Sparc Systems opened a data centre in Lilongwe pitched explicitly at ending Malawian reliance on offshore hosting, joining a further commercial facility in Blantyre. The country's first Tier III site, the National Data Center in Blantyre, opened in 2022, built with ESCOM and Huawei under the ministry responsible for digitalisation. No hyperscale cloud provider maintains a point of presence in Malawi (2025), so enterprise cloud is reached through a regional hub abroad.

Government has settled on holding its own bytes. The Boma Lathu platform runs on locally hosted servers under the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project, and the integration design has each department retain ownership of its data and host it locally rather than pooling it — the arrangement under which immigration services joined the platform in July 2026, with proposed rules routing inter-agency requests through the National Data Centre.

That practice rests on no published rule. Malawi has published no policy on where government data may be held (2025), a national cloud strategy is still being drafted under the same project, and the Data Protection Act 2024 sets conditions for cross-border transfer rather than requiring in-country storage. Whatever sits in these buildings sits on a grid that sheds load nearly every day.

Energy

Electricity reached 15.6 per cent of Malawians in 2023, among the lowest rates in Sub-Saharan Africa, and the split behind that figure is 57.8 per cent of the urban population against 6.1 per cent of the rural population — a gap of about 52 points. Access to energy is the lowest-scoring of all 96 IIAG indicators for Malawi, at 5.9 out of 100 in 2023 and 52nd of 54 African states, up 0.7 points across the decade to 2023. Infrastructure as a whole is the worst of the country's 16 governance sub-categories, at 28.0 out of 100.

What supply exists is unreliable and weather-bound. Around 91 per cent of generation is hydropower (2024), and ESCOM runs near-daily scheduled load shedding across the morning, midday and evening peaks because generation persistently falls short of demand, with further unplanned outages when maintenance, rainfall or cloud cover cut hydro and solar output (2025). The consequences reach the systems built on top: the revenue authority's electronic invoicing runs against blackouts and connectivity gaps (June 2026), and TNM powers its most remote sites with solar rather than the grid.

Off-grid supply is governed by the National Energy Policy 2018 and delivered through the Malawi Rural Electrification Programme and the Rural Electrification Fund, but it is small and fragile: a 2024 study counted 19 mini-grids with 26 megawatts between them, with several earlier mini-grids abandoned over financial and regulatory difficulties.

Technical Capacity

The institution that runs Malawi's identity register has the people but not the kit: the National Registration Bureau has trained thousands of graduates as registration officers and staffs offices in all 28 districts, while depending on donor support for card printers, consumables, connectivity contracts and IT security (2024). That is the pattern across the estate — the register itself is largely donor-financed, and the work of standing up the data protection function was still out to consultancy tender in October 2025.

Administrative capability is not uniformly weak. The IIAG scores Malawi 56.2 out of 100 on effective administration in 2023, 23rd of 54 African states and up 2.6 points over the decade, against a broader public administration score of 49.9 that fell over the same period. Outside government, the universities teach computer science and cybersecurity to doctoral level and country-level developer groups such as Tech Malawi maintain public code repositories and run hackathons, but the state has no digital skills programme for its own workforce (2025) - the training that happens is donors': a development programme reached 5,014 people through digital-skills capacity development in 2025, with nothing stating how many were public servants.

Two internet exchanges now operate. The older has run since December 2008 under the internet service providers' association and migrated its peering to the national data centre in November 2024; the Lilongwe exchange stood up a new switching fabric in December 2025 and took a sustainable peering infrastructure grant in February 2026 to raise port speeds and take more members. Neither publishes a traffic figure, a member count or a port speed, so what crosses either is not on the record.

Cybersecurity

Malawi sits in the top tier of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index (2024) on the strength of its declared commitments, while the rules that would bind anyone are still unwritten: the finance minister told Parliament on 6 August 2026 that stronger cybercrime protection, customer sensitisation and faster reversal of erroneous digital transactions must all come through regulations yet to be made, with no draft published for any of them.

The defensive machinery is lodged inside the telecoms regulator. MACRA has signalled that the national computer emergency response team and the data protection function should stand outside it as independent institutions (July 2026), and it is the body to which the Data Protection Act 2024 directs breach notification within 72 hours. Work on the cybersecurity and data protection frameworks is carrying World Bank support (March 2026), and the central bank's payments strategy for 2026-2030 puts cybersecurity and resilience to power and connectivity failure among its objectives.

DPI

Data Exchange

Malawi's national data exchange platform is built and idle: the Minister of ICT says government institutions still share citizen data by email, USB drive and paper because the binding data-sharing regulation has not been issued, so the infrastructure exists but cannot yet do its job (2026). Boma Lathu itself was implemented under the World Bank-financed Digital Foundations Project, and the government's own enterprise service bus was non-operational through 2025, leaving services siloed. Above the plumbing there is no policy layer either: Malawi has no government interoperability framework, no data-quality or service-availability standards for government data exchange, no programme to retire legacy systems to a common standard, and publishes nothing on the terms under which government data moves (2025).

What does move, moves bilaterally. The Business Registration Act gives the Malawi Revenue Authority standing online access to the business registration database, and a firm must produce its registration certificate to obtain a taxpayer identification number, but the two registrations are never merged. The social registry exchanges data through APIs with the management information systems of the Social Cash Transfer Programme and the public works programme (2022), and the National Registration Bureau offers e-verification and e-KYC to public and private bodies under bilateral memoranda rather than through a shared bus. The cost shows up in small places: tax withheld by the copyright society on royalty payments is not reconciled automatically against a rights holder's taxpayer identification number, so the holder must collect the documents and file them in person or risk being taxed twice (August 2026).

The proposed Government Data Sharing Regulation would route every inter-agency request through the National Data Centre, mandate encryption in transit and at rest, set a common standard for system-to-system exchange and require binding data-sharing agreements with usage limits and full audit trails (June 2026). Districts are not yet in the picture: sub-national participation is planned rather than achieved, with rural connectivity constraining uptake

(2025). A separate 2025-2027 effort with the EU, UNFPA and UNDP is building a Harmonized National Management Information System with the Ministry of Finance to pull sector administrative data together for planning.

Digital Identity and CRVS

More than 13.5 million Malawians hold a national digital identity, about 99 per cent of everyone aged 16 and over (July 2026). That position rests on a mass-registration campaign run between May and November 2017 that enrolled around 9.2 million people, and enrolment continues: over 150,000 people registered between April and June 2026, 53 per cent of them women. Children are reached instead through birth registration, where the Bureau runs civil registration and the national ID as one system, issuing every child a national ID number at birth that is carried for life.

The credential is stronger than the services behind it. Every registrant gives ten fingerprints and an ICAO-standard facial photograph, captured on solar-powered kits, and the card carries a QR code and machine-readable zone that allow it to be authenticated offline — two million voters were registered that way. First registration and card collection are free (2024). Renewal is where the register shows strain: the bureau extended the validity of roughly two million expired cards to 1 January 2027 while it renews, prints and distributes replacements in December 2025, about a tenth of the registered adult population carrying a document kept alive by notice rather than by reissue, and no renewal throughput or completion forecast accompanies it. The bureau's own strategic plan for 2025 to 2030 puts 99 per cent of adults biometrically registered and names its resilience and integration gaps, and nothing independent tests either claim.

What it opens is uneven. The ID is mandatory for opening a bank account and [mandatory for social assistance, with around 1.5 million Affordable Inputs Programme beneficiaries verified biometrically against the register] (2024) (https://www.nrb.gov.mw), but accepted rather than required for public healthcare. The Bureau reports links with more than 33 public and private institutions, including the electoral commission, the civil service payroll, the revenue authority and mobile operators (2025), though the tax link rests on a memorandum of understanding. SIM registration has been compulsory since the Communications Act 2016, and MACRA began nationwide biometric SIM registration in July 2025, tying every SIM to a national ID and biometrics.

A smartphone wallet will complement the plastic card rather than replace it — a person must already hold a national ID to self-register for the digital version — and is designed to need no periodic renewal. The system it would sit on is primarily donor-funded, having drawn over US$73 million from UNDP, DFID, the EU, Irish Aid, Norway, USAID and UNICEF, with government meeting roughly 40 per cent of project costs and struggling with recurrent salaries, card production and IT maintenance (2024).

Digital Payments and Fintech

Malawian mobile money moved K37.9 trillion in 2025, a 94 per cent rise on K19.5 trillion the year before, across 2.4 billion transactions, up 31.6 per cent — and remains overwhelmingly a way of handling cash rather than replacing it. Airtime purchase accounted for 42 per cent of activity in 2025 and cash-in and cash-out for 33.1 per cent, against 7.7 per cent for merchant payments, which the Reserve Bank's own report calls a challenge to the government's digitalisation agenda. The subscriber count flatters the picture too: 19.9 million registered subscriptions in 2025, of which 44.8 per cent — about 8.9 million — were active in a 30-day window.

The rails underneath are old and interoperable. The interbank settlement system has run since 2002 and the national switch since 2015, and NatSwitch added ATM interoperability in 2015, point of sale in 2016 and real-time electronic funds transfer in 2022. The Reserve Bank operates the settlement system directly and holds licensing authority over payment, clearing and settlement systems under the Payment Systems Act 2016, while the retail switch is industry-owned and subject to its oversight rather than its control. Parliament passed Bills phasing out the cheque on 6 August 2026. Wallet ceilings were raised from K1 million to K5 million, with transaction limits lifted to K1 million (2025). Private capacity is filling gaps: a Malawian fintech and Centenary Bank launched instant transfers to any Malawian bank over the national switch, reachable by USSD without a smartphone (June 2025).

Access is the weak point. Access to banking services is among Malawi's ten worst-scoring governance indicators at 17.8 out of 100 in 2023, and 54 per cent of adults owned a registered mobile money account in 2023 against a target of 95 per cent of adults reaching formal financial services by 2028. Government is a laggard in its own market: the social cash transfer programme began paying by mobile money in 2022 and had reached more than ten of 28 districts by mid-2024, and the national e-payment gateway was one of the few government platforms actually delivered in 2025.

Registries

Roughly 4.6 million Malawian children still have no birth certificate, and registering them needs K17.8 billion — of which K5.4 billion was allocated in the 2025/26 financial year for the first two phases, leaving K12.4 billion unfunded (January 2026). The campaign runs in seven phases across 25 districts, using government primary schools as registration centres staffed by trained teachers alongside Bureau personnel. Since the 2015 Act replaced a 1904 law, around 3.8 million children have been registered.

The civil register itself covers births, deaths and marriages and doubles as the national population register, from which WHO's 2022 vital statistics for Malawi were drawn. It is not digital end to end: birth registration still runs on paper forms with distributed issuance at district level, and at rural registration points the informant completes a paper form, a village head signs to verify it, and the certificate is printed later at a facility or district office that has a printer. An integrated digital registration application on biometric tablets remained a Lilongwe district pilot as of mid-2025. Malawi still ranks seventh in Africa on civil registration, but its score fell 25 points over 2014-2023 to 75.0 out of 100, the fourth most deteriorated of its 96 governance indicators.

Vital events consolidated in February 2026: marriage and divorce registration transferred from the Registrar General to the National Registration Bureau, its director becoming Registrar of Marriages, putting births, marriages, divorces and identity under one body. Registration counts for the two new events are not published.

The other registers are thinner. Eighty-nine per cent of Malawi's roughly 1.6 million micro, small and medium enterprises were neither registered nor licensed, with about 11 per cent both registered and paying tax (2019); the registrar was reorganised in June 2026, when the Companies, Registrations and Intellectual Property Centre replaced the Registrar General's department and extended online processing to stamp and estate duty, with no count of registered businesses or processing time published on either side of the change. Formal land registration is concentrated in three district registries, at Blantyre, Lilongwe and Mzuzu, with most land remaining customary; a Land Information Management System launched in February 2024 reached the districts in March 2026, when an implementation support mission trained 647 district land officers and delivered more than 400 computers, over 100 printers and four satellite positioning units. Against that, the agriculture ministry's system had registered and geo-mapped over 3.4 million farming households and their land parcels by December 2024, replacing paper farmer records, and the revenue authority is running property-registration exercises in the three cities to bring untaxed rental property into the net (February 2026). The social registry, which covers several million households with rollout continuing (2024), is the one register wired to the programmes that use it.

Sectoral management information systems

The revenue authority has moved almost its whole VAT base onto real-time electronic invoicing — 8,552 taxpayers registered as of 20 July 2026, against roughly 9,000 registered VAT operators. The system was established under the 2024 amendment to the Value Added Tax Act; the authority let the statutory deadline pass and rescheduled full enforcement and penalties to 1 May 2026, and in use it is constrained by power blackouts and connectivity gaps. Full rollout of the integrated tax administration system finished in April 2025, with more than 90 per cent of large taxpayers filing online.

Where the state meets citizens, capture is still paper. Rural clinics record on paper, with Health Passports as the primary medical record, and electronic health records have been feasible mainly in urban, private or larger government facilities (2025); health data reaches DHIS2 only because clerks transcribe it into paper facility registers that are aggregated and keyed in at district offices. The national health system is being scaled under a 2025 framework mandating integration with e-government platforms that remains under development. Schools are the same: rural primary schools keep records on paper, and the education management information system is compiled from paper census returns rather than captured digitally at school level (2024).

The financial back office is deployed but shallow. The financial management system is in use on commercial software, covers treasury and budget preparation, and is deployed at central government level only, and there is a debt management system but no public investment management system (2025). Deployment is not use: most ministries were still transacting outside the financial management system in real time five years after it reached all 28 of them (2024).

The social insurance system does not use the national identity number and does not exchange data with other government systems (2025), and neither the judiciary's case management system, running since 2015, nor its 2024 e-court pilot is documented as linked to the national data exchange. In May 2026 government retook full control of the traffic information system from its foreign vendor to enable integration with tax, law enforcement and the national ID.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Public procurement went fully electronic before the government's own service portal did: e-procurement became mandatory for all public entities under a March 2026 directive, ending paper-based public procurement, building on earlier World Bank fiscal governance work and extended into a nationwide transparency and value-for-money system. The citizen-facing portal is a generation behind it: Malawi's national public service portal is informational only, publishing information about services rather than allowing most of them to be transacted (2025). The procurement marketplace is integrated with the financial management system, though its integration with a cross-government data exchange is still under development.

The single portal is being filled in service by service. The Department of E-Government is onboarding 25 e-services across ministries, departments and agencies, adding immigration alongside the revenue authority and the National Registration Bureau (July 2026), putting immigration transactions on the same locally hosted national stack as the rest. Malawi scored 0.3753 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024.

Across the 149 GovTech Maturity Index fields recorded for Malawi in 2025, 76 report the item as absent and a further 20 as not assessed, leaving 53 that record something in place — so roughly two-thirds of what the index looks for either is not there or could not be established.

Some of the absences are basic: there is neither an online social protection or benefits portal nor a government jobs and employment portal, and no government citizen participation platform or feedback and grievance channel at all (2025). Where services have gone online they are narrow and recent: a 2024 e-court pilot links a small number of court, prison and police sites for remote bail hearings rather than digitising case capture at rural stations, and a real-time constituency development fund dashboard was launched on 31 July 2026. The passport service shows the pattern in miniature: printing resumed in Mangochi with SMS notification, an online portal and WhatsApp integration all deferred until the new system stabilises (July 2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Malawi's councils have their first dedicated ICT policy: the National Local Government Finance Committee and the Department of E-Government issued an ICT policy for Local Authorities, validated on 4 May 2026, together with ICT standards for councils. Until then councils worked with no guiding ICT framework beyond the 2023 National Digitalization Policy, and a 2022 situational analysis found ICT support weak, ICT projects absent and ICT left out of council procurement.

Very little of the digital state is council-owned. The clearest exception is Blantyre City Council's partnership with NBS Bank to digitise its revenue and tax collection and let residents pay for council services electronically (March 2026). Above the councils, the Ministry of Local Government and Rural Development launched a real-time Constituency Development Fund dashboard in Lilongwe on 31 July 2026 to track project implementation and spending nationally, and has urged communities unhappy with council CDF projects to raise it through the dashboard (August 2026). Reporting the other way is thinner: sub-national participation in the national data exchange is planned rather than achieved, with rural connectivity limiting district uptake (2025).

The money and the machinery both run through the centre. The second Governance to Enable Service Delivery project covers 32 councils, 28 district and 4 municipal, against 28 under its predecessor, bringing the municipal councils of Karonga, Kasungu, Luchenza and Mangochi into the performance-based grant system for the first time (July 2026) after the original project closed on 30 June 2026. The National Local Government Finance Committee implements it, funding re-engineering of council planning, financial management, procurement and contract management, plus a performance dashboard and ICT equipment — systems bought for councils rather than by them.

What the grants measure is drifting apart from what the audits find. The Local Authority Performance Assessment sets eligibility for the grants, and improvement in a council's score is a headline indicator of the new project; 27 of the 28 district councils qualified under the 2025/26 assessment, with Dowa best-performing, while the number of councils with clean audit opinions fell to 18 from 22 in 2023/24 and Nkhotakota drew an adverse opinion (2026).

Rural digital data capture

Farmers across 14 districts enter their details into four platforms that do not talk to each other — the meteorological department's PICSA climate service, One Acre Fund, the government Farm Input Subsidy Programme and ACE's Zaulimi market and warehouse-receipt app — logging into each in turn and losing control of their data (December 2025). Agriculture is where capture at source has gone furthest: farming households and their land parcels have been registered and geo-mapped into a national agriculture management information system (December 2024), and Airtel Money and the state marketing corporation Admarc began paying farmers directly into mobile wallets and moving commodity payments onto electronic rails (June 2026). Applied work is starting at the research base rather than the ministry: the Malawi University of Science and Technology has commissioned an AI fertigation system at its Thyolo campus that doses irrigation and fertiliser from real-time crop data (July 2026).

Outside agriculture the record is still made on paper and travels. Health data from rural facilities is transcribed from patient-held Health Passports into paper registers and keyed into DHIS2 at district offices (2025), with digital point-of-care record-keeping in rural clinics no further than pilots; rural primary schools keep attendance and enrolment on paper, and the education management information system is compiled from paper returns (2024); and a birth is still reported on the paper NR8 form, signed by a village head, with certificates printed later wherever there is a printer. The tablet-based Nzika App meant to replace that chain was still a pilot in Lilongwe district (June 2025) — the capital's own district.

The largest deployment of capture devices beyond the capital has been electoral: the Malawi Electoral Commission put 6,500 electronic devices into the field for the 16 September 2025 elections, which went offline in rural areas. Digital services and data exchange remain concentrated in urban areas while about 80 per cent of the population lives rurally, the Government Wide Area Network is frequently down, and an Open Government Partnership commitment seeks to raise broadband coverage from 38 to 75 per cent through community operators (2025).

Technology

AI

No artificial intelligence was in use in Malawi's citizen-facing government service and feedback channels (2025), and the country has no AI policy in force: a first national AI strategy went into regional consultation in September 2025 and reached a validation workshop in February 2026 alongside a draft digital transformation strategy, neither of them adopted.

The preparation is running ahead of both the policy and the use. The National Data Centre that carries the government's data exchange is being upgraded to an AI-ready state under the World Bank-funded Digital Malawi Acceleration Project, and the Ministry of ICT has run AI training for Principal Secretaries, with no AI capability running in the exchange itself (2026).

The applied AI that does exist in Malawi sits in the research base rather than in a ministry: the Malawi University of Science and Technology has commissioned an AI fertigation system at its Thyolo campus that doses irrigation and fertiliser from live crop data (July 2026), and a Malawi Low Resource Language Data Trust was launched to assemble licensed Chichewa content as training data, with World Bank and Gates Foundation support (June 2026) — a corpus for models that do not yet exist. Beyond the university campus, no artificial intelligence system was established as operating in a Malawian public service as at July 2026.

ICT Industry

Malawi has no startup or innovation law, no government startup financing scheme and no SME support programme for the technology sector (2025), and the sector has grown without either. Formal investment is close to absent: venture funding into Malawian startups is negligible (2024), and the technology sector operates largely without formal startup investment (2024).

What exists instead is a small builder base selling its own work. ICT-services exports more than doubled between 2020 and 2023, making digital services one of the country's growing sources of external earnings, and Sparc Systems has put forward a blueprint for exporting platforms it builds locally — anti-money-laundering compliance, student records, farmer payment systems and CRM across Africa (June 2026). The same firm opened a commercial data centre in Lilongwe aimed at ending reliance on offshore hosting (May 2026), which is where most Malawian firms still keep their data, at a cost in scarce foreign currency. Below the firms sit organised developer groups such as Tech Malawi and Golang Malawi, maintaining public code repositories and running hackathons (2024).

Foreign exchange, not demand, is what bounds the sector's larger players. The ICT minister conceded on the record that foreign-exchange shortages are constraining operators' imports of network equipment (July 2026), and TNM names the same shortage as the limit on its network and innovation spending (November 2025) — a supply-side ceiling that MACRA's cut to spectrum licence fees and Malawi's comparatively strong business and competition regulation do nothing to lift. The government's own large build is carried on donor money rather than domestic purchasing: the national data centre upgrade runs under the World Bank-funded Digital Malawi Acceleration Project (2026).

Innovation ecosystem

Support for Malawian innovators arrives as events and donor grants rather than as policy. National Bank of Malawi committed K75.5 million to the 2025 Innovation Jam, run with the ICT Association of Malawi on the theme "AI for Sustainable Development" (November 2025), under a three-year memorandum with the association covering mentorship and incubation.

The physical base is thin and externally equipped: a small set of technology hubs is active, including mHub, the MUBAS Innovation Hub and Mzuzu E-Hub (2024), the MUBAS hub fitted out under a UNDP grant running to 2026. National ICT Innovation Awards were held in April 2026. One product of the sector is in the market on its own terms: PayChangu runs an SME payments aggregator offering APIs, Shopify and WooCommerce plugins and hosted payment links (April 2026).

Nothing connects any of this to the state as a buyer or an adopter. Government reports a public-sector innovation programme of its own (2025), but no mechanism for public-private collaboration on government innovation is recorded (2025), there is no open source policy or public-sector adoption programme (2025), and no startup law or state financing scheme stands behind the hubs. On the measure that would show any of it working through, Malawi's Global Innovation Index profile puts it in the bottom quartile of ranked economies.

Capacity

Literacy

Malawi's schools are better staffed than they are finished: the supply and qualification of teaching staff scores 86.1 out of 100 (2023), one of the country's ten best governance indicators, while completion stands at 29.8 and enrolment at 38.6, the latter down 3.2 points over the decade to 2023, leaving education one of Malawi's weakest sub-categories at 48.9 and 33rd of 54 African states.

What moved over that decade was fairness and quality rather than reach. Equality in education rose 11.5 points to 46.6 and education quality 7.0 points to 51.9 (2023), the second of those putting Malawi 14th in Africa — a school system judged better at teaching those it holds than at holding them.

Digital literacy diverges from the schooling picture rather than following it. The one national figure is a donor's: an inclusive digital economy scorecard put general-population digital literacy at 18 per cent and the overall skills component at 37 per cent in 2023, and nothing has re-measured it since. No government programme teaches them: nothing reaches citizens or schools, and nothing is published on the digital skills of the public service itself (2025). What has been launched against the gap is external and target-shaped - a free digital-learning platform in October 2025, and an advocates programme certifying 30 university students each set to train 100 community members in February 2026. Rights advocates including the Centre for Human Rights and Rehabilitation have placed digital literacy among the risks of moving the national identity credential onto a smartphone (July 2026), which is the point at which the gap stops being an education statistic and becomes an access condition.

Where digital tools have reached classrooms, they teach rather than record. The BEFIT tablet programme, running in primary schools from 2023 to 2029, supplies foundational literacy and numeracy software and captures no administrative school record; the records themselves are still kept on paper, with the ministry's management information system compiled from paper returns rather than captured at the school.

Training and skills

No arm of the Malawian state is being trained to run the systems the state is building: there is no public-service digital skills strategy or training programme, no government digital skills programme reaching citizens or schools, and nothing published on public-service skills (2025).

The training that does exist is university training, and it is long established. The University of Malawi, the Malawi University of Science and Technology, the Malawi University of Business and Applied Sciences and Mzuzu University all run computer science, IT and cybersecurity programmes from bachelor's to PhD level. What comes out is a thin stream: fewer than one in ten of the country's tertiary graduates were in ICT fields (2022).

New money is arriving as scholarships rather than as curricula, and it names the roles it is buying. The Airtel Africa Foundation's Nzeru Fund, launched in January 2026, carries 25 low-income students through undergraduate degrees at the Malawi University of Science and Technology in IT, computer science, software engineering, data science, artificial intelligence and cybersecurity. Alongside it, a three-year National Bank of Malawi and ICT Association of Malawi memorandum puts mentorship and incubation behind individual innovators rather than behind qualifications, and the defence relationship with China now extends past exchanges into training and institutional development (July 2026).

All of it rests on school connectivity that is mostly absent — most of Malawi's roughly 9,000 schools have limited or no internet access (April 2026) — and the response is being assembled outside the budget rather than inside it. The World Bank is separately connecting more than 200 schools, outside any budget line for school connectivity (April 2026); the CTN initiative carries free long-term high-performance connectivity for more than 20 secondary schools in Lilongwe (August 2026), confined to the capital; and the Digital Malawi Acceleration Project carries a school-connection target an order of magnitude larger than either.

Research institutions

The most concrete applied digital work on Malawi's record this year sits in a university rather than a ministry. The Malawi University of Science and Technology has commissioned an AI fertigation system at its Thyolo campus, automating irrigation and fertiliser dosing from real-time crop data, and the same project runs an AI-assisted smart tree nursery producing drought- and flood-resilient seedlings under the TagDev 2.0 African agricultural-universities programme, led by Dr Jabulani Nyengere (July 2026). Both are single-campus installations.

That work rests on Malawian institutions funded from outside. UNDP is funding a US$2 million grant, active over 2019-2026, to equip the Malawi University of Business and Applied Sciences innovation hub for ideation, prototyping, mentorship, incubation and testing; the four main universities teach computer science and cybersecurity to doctoral level; and more than 83,000 students were connected through the Malawi Research and Education Network (June 2025).

The infrastructure around that work moved in 2026. The research and education network launched a national federated repository with digital object identifier support in February; a university began a twelve-month project evaluating large language models for primary-healthcare settings with the health ministry and the medical council in

April; and the country's one dedicated digital-policy think tank is a not-for-profit company whose stated mission is independent advocacy, consultancy and research. None of the three publishes a spend, a headcount or an output count.

Language is where the country has begun assembling a resource rather than drawing on someone else's. A Malawi Low Resource Language Data Trust launched in June 2026 to gather licensed local-language content as training data for Chichewa AI models, supported by the World Bank and the Gates Foundation, with digital assistants, translation and education named as the intended applications — the one asset here that other people's models will have to come to Malawi for.

Inclusion

Access to services

Affordability is now a stated government target rather than only an industry ask. The ICT minister called on 21 August 2026 for the 10 per cent surtax on internet services to be scrapped and the 17.5 per cent VAT on smartphones reviewed, setting a target of lifting mobile internet use from 12.5 per cent to at least 30 per cent by 2030, with MACRA evaluating Universal Service Fund mechanisms to subsidise consumer devices and fund digital-literacy work including a proposed one-tablet-one-student programme; no budget measure or bill is on record. Industry had asked for the same in January 2026, adding zero-rating of traffic to government portals, so that reaching a public service does not first cost a data bundle. Pressure from below runs the same way: more than 885 people signed a petition in about a day in July 2026 asking MACRA to review internet prices, days after the regulator approved tariff increases well below what the two operators had asked for, and the petitioners also want it to look into data-billing and bundle-depletion practices and publish what it finds.

The gate on the state's own services is the national ID, which is mandatory for social assistance, including biometric verification of Affordable Inputs Programme beneficiaries, and for opening a bank account. The document itself is not the cost barrier — first registration and collection are free — and adult coverage is now close to universal, so what matters is who cannot obtain one. Refugees at Dzaleka can bank, through a branch opened in the camp, but a registered SIM for mobile money generally requires a national ID most of them cannot get (2024), and non-nationals may register only on a valid immigration permit.

Little of this is transactable online in any case: the national services portal is informational rather than transactional and there is no social protection or benefits portal, so obtaining a service still means reaching a counter or an agent in person. That distance is itself the barrier for some — a 2024 study found people with disabilities struggle to travel to mobile money agents, on a rail whose main channel is text-based USSD. Malawi scored 36.4 out of 100 for equal access to public services in 2023, 30th of 54 African states, inside an Inclusion & Equality score of 44.4 that has drifted down over the decade to 2023.

Digital divides

Only 54 per cent of Malawian adults own a mobile phone of any kind (2023), which puts the country's first divide at the handset rather than the network: for close to half the adult population, what the network reaches is not yet the binding question. Price is the next gate. A mobile broadband basket cost 9.4 per cent of gross national income per capita in 2022, and Malawi's score for internet and computer access and affordability sits near the bottom of its whole Ibrahim Index profile.

The gap between women and men runs at 15 percentage points in mobile internet use (2024). It is not uniform across the digital estate: the equivalent gap in mobile money narrowed in 2025, and the identity register's enrolment ran majority-female in the quarter to June 2026, closing its own gender gap rather than widening it.

The rural line is cut hardest by electricity, where the urban access rate is many times the rural one (2023), and it is now being cut again by policy. As Parliament took the Bill withdrawing cheques, an MCP member warned that rural Malawi risks being left behind unless government fixes patchy internet coverage (August 2026), and Sosten Gwengwe — chair of the joint committee that reported the Bill, and a supporter of the phase-out — told the House that "someone in a village should be able to send or receive money without being blocked by poor connectivity", citing unreliable debit notifications and the difficulty of reversing failed transactions.

Schooling divides the next generation before the market does: about 900 of Malawi's roughly 9,000 schools have no internet at all and the great majority have limited access or none (April 2026). And the shift to a smartphone-based digital ID adds a device test to a credential most adults already hold, which is why rights advocates including the Centre for Human Rights and Rehabilitation warn of equal-access, rural-exclusion and digital-literacy risks (July 2026).

Data

National statistics

Malawi's statistical system is rated far stronger on what is done with the numbers than on where they come from: the World Bank puts the country above 89% on data use and 70-89% on data products, but at 20-49% on both data sources and data infrastructure, with data services in between (2023). The collection record bears that out. A population census and a business census have both been run within the last ten years, while the most recent agricultural census falls only within the last twenty (2023); over the decade to 2023 the country ran three or more household, health and business surveys each, two labour surveys and a single agricultural survey. Agriculture is the one domain the counts identify outright as thin.

The composite measures put it more flatly: the Mo Ibrahim Foundation's Capacity of the Statistical System indicator scores Malawi 48.1 out of 100.0 in 2023, 27th of 54 African states and up 2.2 points across the decade to 2023. The weakness in sources shows in the plumbing — health data from rural facilities reaches the national system by clerks transcribing patient-held records into paper registers that district offices then key in (2025), while the country's vital statistics are drawn from the national population register (2022). A 2025-2027 project with the Ministry of Finance is building a harmonised management information system to pull sector administrative data together for planning.

What counting badly costs is on show at the Copyright Society of Malawi, which distributes its statutory Blank Media Levy entirely on records of which songs customers ask licensed CD- and DVD-burning centres to copy, a methodology it states is not based on digital consumption and which an Annual General Meeting declined to replace (August 2026). Of roughly K3bn collected under the levy in 2026, COSOMA puts K150m to the Malawi Revenue Authority as an administration fee, K150m to government, K300m to the Copyright Fund and K1.8bn to rights holders, from which a further 20% is withheld as tax.

About K1.44bn — some 48% of the pool — reaches rights holders once every deduction is taken (2026).

Open data

Malawi ranks 3rd of 54 African states on disclosure of public records, scoring 57.7 out of 100.0 after a 19.3-point rise over the decade to 2023 — and 22nd, at 33.9, on whether disclosed records can actually be reached and used. Publication has improved far faster than access to it. A national open data portal for budget, project and service-delivery data was launched by the open government secretariat in September 2025, after the index recorded none in that year; the announcement does not link to the live portal and no dataset count or licence is stated. Behind it there is still no government data governance institution and no government data strategy, and nothing published on how the state governs its own data, and the only instrument titled an open data policy covers extractive-industry data.

Nor do the government's own systems report on themselves: the digital transformation coordinating institution, the national service portal, the e-procurement system and the debt management system all record no public reporting of usage or performance (2025).

The right to ask is in better shape than the supply. An access to information law is in force and assessed as effective, giving the public a right to request government records (2025). What that right reaches is modest: on Open Data Watch's 2024 inventory Malawi's economic and financial statistics all sit in the 3-5 out of 10 band — balance of payments, government finance and prices at 5, labour 4.5, trade, banking and national accounts 4 — and population statistics are the best-scoring category of all at 5.5, ahead of health outcomes and reproductive health at 5 and gender, poverty and food security at 4.5. Land and environment data score lower again, at 3.5 for agriculture and land use, 3.5 for natural resources and 4.5 for the built environment. Where publication is routine it is sectoral, as with the Reserve Bank's quarterly national payment systems reports (2024).

Two additions in mid-2026 run the other way. In June the government launched a Malawi Low Resource Language Data Trust to assemble licensed local-language content as training data for Chichewa AI models, supported by the World Bank and the Gates Foundation, with digital assistants, translation and education named as the intended uses. On 31 July the Ministry of Local Government and Rural Development opened a real-time Constituency Development Fund dashboard in Lilongwe, letting government and the public track CDF project implementation and spending nationally.

Use of satellite data

Two uses are now on the record and neither is a programme. The climate change and meteorological services department installed the 2025 generation of the regional satellite reception system in August 2025, giving it access to third-generation geostationary products, and its staff took operational training on it that October. Separately the agriculture ministry uses a satellite-based in-season yield model, which the national committee on crop estimates has recommended incorporating into the national crop-estimate survey. No national earth-observation strategy, budget line or data product from either is published, and nothing connects the meteorological capability to the agricultural use that would be its most obvious domestic customer.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American footprint in Malawi's digital estate is a financier's, and the earlier of the two grants behind it has already closed: USAID's Support for Scaling up Mobile Money in Malawi ran from 2012 to 2018 and ended there. What has followed is study rather than build — the US Trade and Development Agency funded a feasibility study on expanding fixed wireless and fibre broadband access networks (2022) — which pays for a plan and commits nobody to laying cable.

The one American-aligned project sitting close to a core system arrives through a multilateral rather than a bilateral channel: the Boma Lathu national data exchange was implemented under the World Bank-financed Malawi Digital Foundations Project. No US hyperscaler held a data-centre region, a cable landing or a government hosting contract in Malawi as at August 2026. The United States holds nothing in the estate that a Malawian system would have to work around: no infrastructure, no hosting and no vendor position.

China activities

China's footprint in Malawi extended into defence in 2026: the Defence Minister told a People's Liberation Army anniversary event in Lilongwe in July 2026 that the Malawi Defence Force intends to adopt artificial intelligence in military operations and to learn it from the Chinese army, and both governments described a relationship that now runs past exchanges into specialised training, equipment supply and institutional development, with further equipment and command-level training under discussion. No contract or timetable has been announced, and what is described is a training pipeline rather than equipment the state would own — a different kind of dependency from a purchase, because it puts the doctrine on loan along with the tools.

That sits on an established commercial position. Huawei built Malawi's first Tier III data centre, the National Data Center in Blantyre, which opened in 2022 with ESCOM under the ministry responsible for information and digitalisation, and was the network vendor when TNM launched the country's first 5G service in Lilongwe in July 2025. The first phase of the national fibre backbone was built on a Chinese government concessional loan, and China Construction Bank is financing last-mile connectivity for rural areas together with the national data centre. One foreign vendor is therefore present in the national backbone, the state's primary data centre and a mobile operator's radio network at once.

Chinese state lenders are the second-largest source of finance for Malawi's digital estate, behind the World Bank and ahead of every other financier, across three commitments.

The next step is on the table rather than signed. In June 2026 the ICT Minister presented a proposed four-year roadmap with Huawei, covering a one-stop digital-government portal for passports, business registration and tax and a 28-district ring-protected network to carry the Boma Lathu platform; its funding terms are not public. Taken up as presented, it would put the network carrying the government's own data exchange with the vendor that already holds the backbone and the data centre.

EU activities

Europe's presence in Malawi's digital estate is concentrated in the state's own record-keeping rather than in networks or platforms. The bigger of the two European grants is Germany's: BMZ has an active EUR 28.35 million grant running 2022 to 2028 for public financial and economic management, working on the legal framework for public financial administration and on the new Integrated Financial Management Information System. The European Union's own money is smaller and newer — a EUR 2 million contract under Inclusive Digital Transformation for Malawi, active 2024 to 2028, whose stated objective is to strengthen democratic governance and the social contract — and it runs alongside a 2025-2027 project with UNFPA and UNDP building a Harmonized National Management Information System with the Ministry of Finance to integrate sector administrative data for planning.

The identity register shows most clearly what this buys. Malawi's national identity programme is run by the National Registration Bureau with sustained external support from UNDP, the European Union, Norway and Irish Aid (July 2026), which makes the country's foundational register a partly donor-funded operation and its remaining coverage gap partly a donor-funding question. The money continues to arrive and its digital share continues not to be stated: the Union launched a EUR 143 million annual action plan for Malawi on 21 August 2026, four months after a fourth partnership dialogue covering new gateway investments. What Europe holds is a say in how the financial, statistical and identity systems of the state are designed, exercised through the money that builds them, and no infrastructure at all.

Gulf/UAE activities

The Gulf position is memoranda rather than assets. Five memoranda were signed during an Emirati ministerial visit to Lilongwe in May 2025, one of them a digital-learning cooperation agreement between a Gulf school programme and the government, and in November 2025 Malawi launched a Dubai-based climate-data platform built on machine learning and distributed ledgers at the climate conference. Both accounts come from the counterparty's side; nothing Malawian states what either commits the country to, what data the platform holds or where it holds it, and no investment figure attaches to any of it. No Gulf state, sovereign fund or Gulf-owned operator holds a stake, contract or hosting position in the estate itself.

India activities

India's engagement is a standing framework with nothing delivered under it on the record. India's own bilateral brief confirms the tele-education and tele-medicine network programme and a power-sector memorandum as the standing engagements, neither carrying a delivery figure. In April 2026 officials met for a demonstration of India's unified payments interface, the most significant engagement in the window and one at which no memorandum was signed. Malawi already runs a national switch of its own, so what an interface built elsewhere would displace is the question the record does not answer. No Indian corporate holds a stake, contract or hosting position in the estate.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/MWI/MWI-status.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/MWI/MWI-status-2026-09-01.pdf
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